

Chapter 15-1

Why not just get divorced?

This thought briefly appeared in Liang Shi's mind.

This job was undoable.

The original body had left behind too many messes, like a tangled ball of yarn with no beginning thread to be found—impossible to cut through and even more impossible to untangle.

When she came out of Xu Qingzhu's hospital room, Bai Weiwei was still trying to persuade Xu Qingzhu to divorce.

Xu Qingzhu didn't really react, her expression remained indifferent. Although she didn't look well, she also didn't bring up divorce.

But Liang Shi had never been good at handling these kinds of situations.

Interpersonal relationships were so difficult!

She almost couldn't hold it together and nearly got into an argument with Bai Weiwei.

Even though she didn't argue, she was still in a bad mood when she came out of the hospital room.

This damn system—what kind of ridiculous mission was this!

The original body was such trash—couldn't they just kill her off directly?

Let Xu Qingzhu be a young widow, wealthy and free, let her be an ordinary person—wouldn't that work?

Why force her to pursue Xu Qingzhu?

Liang Shi sat on a bench in the hospital for a while.

This was a small path that people often came to for shade in summer, but in autumn, very few people came. Plus the recent bad weather—the autumn wind getting colder day by day—and the hospital being full of people with poor health, this place was very quiet.

She gulped down a belly full of ice water, slightly cooling down her anger.

Even clay figures have some temper¹.

People used to say that Liang Shi lived like an immortal.

Her assistant Jingjing often said, "Teacher Liang is a banished immortal from heaven who never gets angry."

Faced with Jingjing's teasing, Liang Shi would just smile, "It's not that exaggerated."

She simply felt it wasn't necessary.

But her current circumstances made her very mentally exhausted.

She could understand that the system had given her a chance at a new life, so it wanted her to do some things—in other words, pay some price.

But without telling her anything, how was she supposed to do it?

Really just giving her a broken wooden sword and forcing her to fight a dragon?

Too challenging.

Autumn skies changed extremely quickly. The sun had just been hanging in the sky, but in no time, large patches of dark clouds moved in, covering the sky and making it look gloomy, as if a storm was brewing.

The autumn wind swept up fallen leaves, and withered branches and dead leaves swirled as they were blown away.

Liang Shi sneezed. After a while, she took out her phone and replied to Qiu Zimin's message: 【Got it, I'll be there on time.】

Just keep living.

Take it one step at a time.

At this point, there was no better solution.

Liang Shi decided not to clean up the original body's messes anymore.

Being herself—wasn't that happier?

Anyway, she probably wouldn't live much longer.

As for the system?

Let it do whatever it wanted.

What did it have to do with her?

Having thought this through, Liang Shi's mood improved.

Even her speed in replying to Qiu Zimin's messages picked up.

"That's good then," Qiu Zimin's voice message came quickly, "You know the Zhou family's influence. Your father has recently set his sights on a piece of land in the south of the city. Whether it can be approved still depends on Zhou Liye², so take advantage of this opportunity to get along well with Yi'an."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Yi'an likes you—everyone knows that," Qiu Zimin sent another voice message, still quite long, "Don't take advantage of her feelings and act recklessly. Now is different from before. You need to know that the Zhou family is not what it used to be—they've connected with the Shen family line and soared to new heights³. If you still want your father to provide financing for the Xu family, then don't mess around and talk properly with Yi'an."

Liang Shi: "..."

She listened to the voice message twice, trying hard to do reading comprehension.

Later she converted it to text.

She roughly understood.

But the first question she thought of was: The original body was such trash—why would Zhou Yi'an like her?

Was she blind?

Through the screen, Liang Shi hadn't seen Qiu Zimin either, so she just replied: 【Got it.】

A standard response.

She turned off her phone screen and let out an almost imperceptible sigh.

"What are you thinking about?" A clear, cold voice suddenly rang out beside her ear.

It startled Liang Shi.

Her eyelid even twitched as she covered her heart and leaned back slightly, just in time to look up and see who it was—Xu Qingzhu.

Footnotes:

¹ **Even clay figures have some temper (泥人都有三分脾氣):** A Chinese idiom meaning that even the most patient person has limits and will eventually get angry if pushed too far.

² **Zhou Liye (周禮燁):** Zhou Yi'an's family member who apparently has influence over land approval decisions, indicating the Zhou family's political connections.

³ **Soared to new heights (一朝飛上枝頭):** Part of a Chinese idiom "一朝飛上枝頭變鳳凰" (once flying to the treetops, becoming a phoenix), meaning to suddenly rise in social status or power.

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Liang Shi let out a breath, "You scared me." Then she complained in a low voice, "Do you walk without making any sound?"

"I do make sound," Xu Qingzhu sat on the bench, not far from her. The buttons of her white knit cardigan were unfastened, swaying in the wind at the moment, making her whole person look ethereally graceful. Even her voice carried a few traces of cool, spiritual quality, "You were just too absorbed in your thoughts to hear."

"Alright." Liang Shi took another gulp of ice water and asked casually, "What do you need me for?"

"Can't I look for you if there's nothing?" Xu Qingzhu asked back.

"...You can." Liang Shi pressed her temples and gave her a brief once-over from the side.

Mm, quite beautiful.

She withdrew her gaze.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said quietly, "Thank you."

Liang Shi was puzzled, "Huh?"

Thank me for what?

"Yesterday you took me back to the hospital," Xu Qingzhu said, "And also, about Yaya's matter."

"Those were small things," Liang Shi said, "I did them in passing. Besides, you're my wife."

Liang Shi said this casually, but after saying it, she sensed the awkwardness.

Would this seem like sexual harassment?!

Having lived in that world for a long time, Liang Shi was a bit paranoid about everything.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu didn't react much. She just lightly repeated those two words—"wife."

Liang Shi's ears grew hot, and she felt the glands behind her ears start to itch.

She rubbed her ears, "Is there anything else? If not, I'll go first."

She also wanted to calm down for a bit.

Only after completely calming down could she think about how to pursue Xu Qingzhu and complete the system's mission.

"Liang Shi," Xu Qingzhu called out to stop her.

"What is it?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused, "Is the Liang family facing a crisis?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"I don't know," Liang Shi answered matter-of-factly, "I never really pay attention to the company's operational status."

With Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe around, she didn't even go to the company.

The original body was just an ignorant, playboy rich second generation.

"Did you hear something?" Liang Shi inquired.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and looked up at her, their eyes meeting.

After a moment, she asked, "Then why are you going to meet Zhou Yi'an?"

Liang Shi hadn't expected Xu Qingzhu to ask so directly, and with such an open attitude.

But after asking, she added, "If you don't want to say, that's fine too."

Liang Shi inexplicably felt like she was having an affair outside and got caught by the legitimate wife.

She thought about it, "Then I choose not to say."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "Okay."

Xu Qingzhu stood up and pulled her knit cardigan tighter, "I'll go first."

After saying this, she walked toward the inpatient building without looking back.

Liang Shi quickened her pace and fell into step just a foot away from Xu Qingzhu's shoulder.

Very close—close enough that her long hair could lightly brush against her face.

Even the ends of her hair carried the rich strawberry sweet scent.

"I haven't figured it out yet," Liang Shi added, "I'll only know everything after I meet her, so I can't tell you. Saying anything now would be irresponsible."

Xu Qingzhu stopped and turned to look at her.

After a moment, she suddenly smiled and asked, "Liang Shi, will you always be like this?"

Liang Shi was puzzled, "Hm?"

She felt like she couldn't understand Xu Qingzhu.

It seemed like for an instant, Xu Qingzhu's clear eyes could see right through her, leaving her with nowhere to hide.

She had the illusion—that she could be completely herself in front of Xu Qingzhu without any restraint.

But it was just her illusion.

She definitely wouldn't do that now.

"Being like this now is quite good," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "..."

She replied perfunctorily, "I guess it's okay."

"By the way," Xu Qingzhu took out a folded paper star from her knit cardigan pocket and handed it to Liang Shi, "You left this in the hospital room."

Liang Shi took it, "Thank you."

Liang Shi had a habit of folding paper stars.

When she was troubled, she would casually fold them.

The returned star still retained some warmth.

As if reminding Liang Shi that the person who had held it before wasn't someone cold and heartless.

Footnotes:

No cultural references requiring footnotes in this chapter.

Chapter 15-3

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Liang Shi arrived at Cangyue Restaurant at 7:20.

Qiu Zimin had already booked a private room. When she went in, Zhou Yi'an hadn't arrived yet.

Liang Shi found a seat and sat down. Soon, the door was pushed open.

Only Zhou Yi'an came.

She wore a custom-tailored suit—white suit pants with slightly rolled cuffs, shiny black leather shoes, a white suit jacket with a black tie, purely an ascetic style¹.

Liang Shi stood up and nodded to her, "Hello."

Zhou Yi'an curved her lips with a wicked smile, "Hello baby, long time no see."

Liang Shi: "..."

She sensed something indescribable.

But it was all just feelings—nothing she could confirm.

Liang Shi didn't like this kind of address much—it was quite greasy.

Especially coming from a stranger's mouth.

But given that she currently knew nothing, she could only endure it, though she still instinctively frowned.

"Baby, did you miss me?" Zhou Yi'an walked toward her with an alluring smile, then suddenly hooked her chin without warning, "During the days we haven't seen each other, I've been thinking about you so much..."

Liang Shi immediately dodged and interrupted her, "Show some respect."

"Huh?" Zhou Yi'an laughed, "Didn't you come to discuss wedding plans with me?"

"I'm already married," Liang Shi said, "Whatever my mother told you doesn't count."

"Is that so?" Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow, "Then the Liang family doesn't want that piece of land in the south of the city anymore?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She said coldly, "If Grandpa Liang² wants the land in the south, you can go discuss it with him. There's no need to come looking for me."

Grandpa Liang was the original body's father.

"But baby, what should I do? I only want you," Zhou Yi'an approached again. Liang Shi's temples throbbed with pain. Almost instinctively, she threw a punch, directly hitting Zhou Yi'an.

"Fuck," Liang Shi cursed in anger, "Get lost."

She grabbed her phone from the table and headed for the door, but Zhou Yi'an grabbed her wrist.

But Liang Shi wasn't someone to mess with either—she directly twisted Zhou Yi'an's arm.

The phone suddenly rang, the contact showing "Bamboo."

Liang Shi answered with one hand, "Hello?"

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Are you done meeting?"

"Who is it?" Zhou Yi'an suddenly spoke up. Liang Shi applied force to twist her arm harder, making Zhou Yi'an grunt in pain, "Damn, I just love this kind of thing."

Liang Shi: "..."

This person had Stockholm syndrome or something.

Idiot.

She cursed in her mind.

"Check your WeChat," Xu Qingzhu said, "I sent you a message."

Liang Shi replied, "Okay."

"Is this your little lover?" Zhou Yi'an asked provocatively with a laugh.

Liang Shi said angrily, "Shut up."

Her finger accidentally hit the speakerphone, and Zhou Yi'an's words reached Xu Qingzhu's ears.

Zhou Yi'an chuckled lightly, "Baby, just how many little lovers do you have? But it doesn't matter."

"Baby," Xu Qingzhu's cool, detached voice sounded through the phone, carrying a cold and distant ambiguous feeling, "Why are you letting someone else call you baby again? I'm getting jealous."

Liang Shi's throat tickled.

Her face suddenly felt hot.

"No," Liang Shi instinctively explained.

"Baby wife, I miss you," Xu Qingzhu said softly, her voice making one's heart itch, "When are you coming home?"

Liang Shi swallowed, even her ears were burning, "I'll be home right away."

"Then I'll hang up," Xu Qingzhu said, "Be careful on the way home, I'll wait for you. Mua~³"

Liang Shi lightly pressed her lips together, her heart beating extremely fast.

After hanging up, she released Zhou Yi'an, "Get lost."

"Baby, sooner or later you'll come back begging me," Zhou Yi'an said behind her.

Liang Shi had already left.

Her ears were filled with Xu Qingzhu's voice.

She pinched her earlobes—they were hot as if on fire.

Walking outside the restaurant, the cold wind blew, and she finally became slightly more sober. She took out her phone to check WeChat messages.

Xu Qingzhu had sent her two messages ten minutes ago:

【Zhou Yi'an is an Alpha.】

【If you don't mind, pretend I never said this.】

Liang Shi now understood what her uncomfortable feeling had been.

In that instant, it was like a basin of ice water had been poured over her head.

Footnotes:

¹ **Ascetic style (禁欲風格):** A fashion style that emphasizes restraint, minimalism, and understated elegance, often associated with conservative or sophisticated looks that suggest self-control and discipline.

² **Grandpa Liang (梁祖):** Here used as a respectful way to refer to Liang Shi's father, emphasizing the generational hierarchy and formal respect in business contexts.

³ **Mua~:** An onomatopoeia for a kissing sound, often used playfully in text messages to represent a kiss.